

Mentorship Platform — Website Build Guide

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Summary

Build a MERN web app where students book near-peer mentors, pay through Razorpay, and join video sessions inside our own site using a hosted video SDK, not by building video ourselves and not by sending Zoom links.

- **Video:** use a video SDK such as LiveKit Cloud (free tier of 5,000 participant-minutes a month to start) embedded in our session page. Keep Google Meet links as a backup for Phase 0 tests before the app exists.
- **Booking:** our own slot system (mentor availability → bookable slots → group or 1:1 session), with Google Calendar invites sent automatically.
- **Payments:** Razorpay checkout for students; Razorpay Route to split each payment between mentor and platform.
- **Notifications:** email for everything, WhatsApp for reminders, in-app for the rest. SMS only for login OTP.
- **Safety and law:** verify mentors, keep all contact on the platform, and design consent flows for users under 18 now, since India's data protection law requires verifiable parental consent for them.
- **Build approach:** write a set of Markdown spec files from this doc, then build module by module with Claude Code, starting with auth, profiles, booking and payments, and adding video last.

Who uses it and what they do

Four kinds of users, each with a short journey; the student journey is the one to get perfect first.

Student (mentee)

1. Signs up with phone OTP or Google; enters age. Under 18 → parent consent step (see Laws).
2. Takes a 2-minute matching quiz: college, branch, year, home state, language, first-generation graduate or not, goal (internship, job, abroad, skills, college life).
3. Sees matched mentors and upcoming group sessions; filters by language, topic, price.
4. Books a slot and pays (or sends a payment link to a parent).
5. Gets confirmation + reminders; joins the session from the site.

6. Rates the session, gets notes and next steps, books again.

Parent

1. Receives a payment or consent link from the student.
2. Gives consent (for under-18 students) and pays.
3. Gets a short monthly progress note.

Mentor

1. Applies: background, college, current role, languages, topics, LinkedIn, proof (offer letter, college ID or employee ID).
2. Admin reviews and approves; mentor completes a short code-of-conduct module.
3. Sets weekly availability, session types (1:1 or group), and prices within our allowed range.
4. Runs sessions, writes a 2-line summary after each, sees earnings and payouts.

Admin (our team)

1. Approves or rejects mentors; can suspend anyone.
2. Handles reports, refunds and disputes.
3. Sees bookings, revenue, ratings, no-shows; features good mentors.

Video calls: which option

Use Google Meet links for the no-code pilot, then embed LiveKit Cloud in our own session page; building video from scratch is not worth it at our stage.

Option	How it works	Cost	Good	Bad
External links (Google Meet, Zoom)	We create a meeting link per booking and send it	Free or low	Zero video code; works today	Users leave our site; no attendance tracking; mentors may use personal accounts; hard to enforce safety rules

Option	How it works	Cost	Good	Bad
LiveKit Cloud (video SDK)	Video room embedded in our page via SDK	Free Build tier: 5,000 participant-min/month; Ship \$50/month with 150,000 min, then about \$0.0005/min (apicostcalc)	Cheapest at scale; open source, so we can self-host later	Monthly plan once we pass the free tier
100ms / Daily / VideoSDK	Same idea, pay per minute	About \$0.004 per participant-minute after free minutes (Fora Soft on Daily)	Very easy prebuilt UIs; 100ms is an Indian company	Expensive for group sessions (see below)
Zoom Video SDK	Zoom's engine inside our app	\$3.50 per 1,000 min after 10,000 free/month	Trusted brand, stable	Pricier than LiveKit at scale
Build our own (self-hosted WebRTC)	Run our own media and TURN servers	Servers + DevOps time	Full control	Months of work, reliability problems; only worth it at very large scale

Why group sessions decide this: one group session of 1 mentor + 10 students for 60 minutes = 660 participant-minutes.

- At \$0.004/min that's about \$2.64 per session, roughly ₹220, which eats most of our ~₹250 cut from a ₹99 × 10 session.
- On LiveKit Ship (\$50 for 150,000 min) the same session costs about \$0.22, roughly ₹19.
- The free 5,000 minutes cover about 7 group sessions a month: fine for the MVP launch, not beyond.

(Rupee figures are approximate conversions.)

Recommendation by phase:

1. **Phase 0 (no app):** Google Meet links from a shared company Google Workspace account, never mentors' personal links.
2. **MVP:** LiveKit Cloud Build (free) embedded in a `/session/:id` page; only booked, paid users get a join token.
3. **Growth:** LiveKit Ship (\$50/month). Self-host LiveKit only if costs justify a DevOps person.

Must-haves in our video page: join only with a valid token in the booking window, mentor can mute/remove participants, a "report" button, low-bandwidth mode (audio-only toggle) for students on weak mobile data, and no recording by default (recording needs everyone's consent).

Booking and scheduling

Build our own slot system on top of MongoDB, store every time in UTC, and send Google Calendar invites; an off-the-shelf scheduler would fight our group-session and payment rules.

How a slot is born:

1. Mentor sets weekly availability (e.g. Sat 10:00–13:00 IST) and blocked dates.
2. System cuts it into bookable slots: 30-min 1:1 or 60-min group (capacity 5–15).
3. Student picks a slot → slot is **held for 10 minutes** while they pay.
4. Payment success (Razorpay webhook) → booking **confirmed**; seat count updates.
5. Payment fails or times out → hold released.

Session states: held → confirmed → live → completed, plus cancelled_by_student, cancelled_by_mentor, no_show_student, no_show_mentor, refunded.

Rules to decide and show clearly (suggested defaults):

Situation	Rule
Student cancels 24h+ before	Full refund or credit
Student cancels under 24h	Credit only, no cash refund
Mentor cancels	Full refund + priority rebooking; repeated cancels lower mentor ranking
Student no-show (10 min)	Session counts as used
Mentor no-show (10 min)	Full refund; mentor gets a strike, 3 strikes = suspended
Group session under minimum (e.g. 3 seats) 6h before	Auto-cancel, full refund

Calendar sync: use the Google Calendar API to send invites from a company account, with the session page link inside. Later, let mentors connect their Google Calendar so busy times block slots automatically.

Time zones: store UTC, show in the user's zone. This matters for abroad mentors (Germany, Canada, Australia).

Alternative considered: Cal.com (open-source scheduler) can embed booking pages quickly, but group capacity, our payment split and our safety rules are easier to own in our code. Worth it only if we want booking live in days rather than weeks.

Payments and mentor payouts

Students pay through Razorpay Checkout (UPI, cards, netbanking), and Razorpay Route splits each payment between the mentor and us, so we never handle payouts by hand.

How money flows:

1. Student (or parent via payment link) pays ₹99 for a group seat.
2. Payment is captured by our Razorpay account.
3. After the session is marked **completed**, our backend creates a Route transfer: about 75% to the mentor's Linked Account, 25% stays with us.
4. Razorpay settles the mentor's share to their bank and sends us a webhook.

[Razorpay Route](#) is built for this one-to-many marketplace model: we add mentors as Linked Accounts, split payments, and reverse transfers when a refund is needed.

Razorpay also asks platforms to submit a written description of their Route use case for RBI payer-payee transparency before Route is enabled ([Razorpay docs](#)), so apply early.

Design decisions:

- **Transfer after the session, not at booking.** This makes refunds for mentor no-shows simple.
- **Mentor KYC:** PAN + bank account + penny test via Razorpay when a mentor is approved.
- **Parent payment link:** Razorpay Payment Links let a student send a link to a parent's phone.
- **Abroad mentors:** Route pays Indian bank accounts. For mentors living abroad, start with mentors who still hold an Indian account; add an international payout option later.
- **Credits wallet:** cancellations under 24h become platform credits, not cash refunds (cheaper and simpler).
- **Never store card or bank details ourselves.** Razorpay handles them; we keep only IDs.

Notifications

Use email for every event, WhatsApp utility templates for the few messages that must be seen, and in-app notifications for the rest; WhatsApp utility messages cost about ₹0.145 each in India.

Event	Student	Mentor	Parent	Channel
Signup / login OTP	Yes	Yes	—	SMS or WhatsApp authentication
Booking confirmed	Yes	Yes	If they paid	Email + WhatsApp + calendar invite
Reminder 24h before	Yes	Yes	—	Email
Reminder 15 min before (with join link)	Yes	Yes	—	WhatsApp + in-app
Session cancelled / rescheduled	Yes	Yes	If they paid	Email + WhatsApp
Session summary + next steps	Yes	—	—	Email + in-app
Rate your session	Yes	—	—	In-app
Payout sent	—	Yes	—	Email
Monthly progress note	—	—	Yes	Email or WhatsApp
Mentor application decision	—	Yes	—	Email

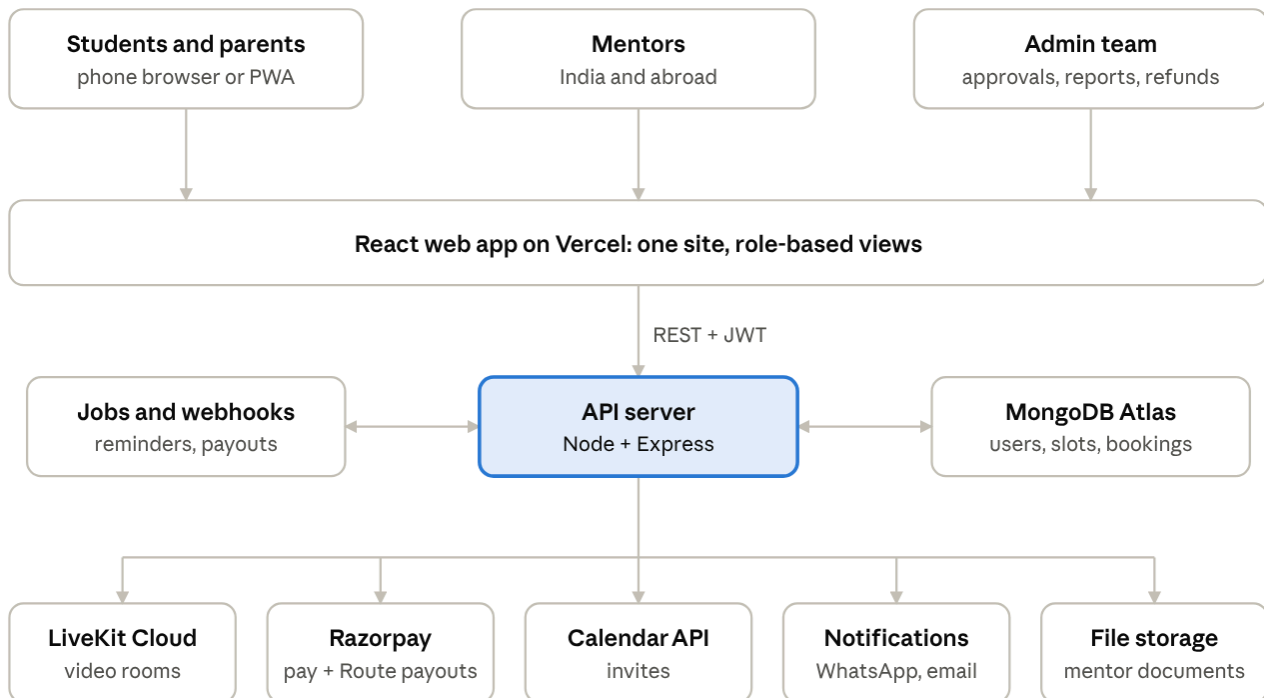
Costs and rules:

- WhatsApp charges per delivered template message; in India utility messages are about ₹0.145 each and marketing messages roughly ₹0.78–0.88 ([Robylon](#), [AiSensy](#)). Keep reminders as **utility** templates, never marketing.
- From 1 October 2026, each number gets 1,000 free service messages a month, then charges apply ([AiSensy](#)).
- Access WhatsApp through Meta's Cloud API directly or a provider (AiSensy, Interakt, Gupshup). Templates need Meta approval.
- Email: Resend, Brevo or Amazon SES (cheap at our volume).
- Every user can switch off non-essential messages; marketing messages only with opt-in.

Tech architecture

One React web app and one Node/Express API serve all four user types; outside services handle video, payments, calendar, messages and files.

One web app and one API server connect users to video, payments and messages



platform architecture · 12 parts

The API issues short-lived LiveKit tokens; the video itself then flows directly between browsers and LiveKit, not through our server.

Stack: React + Vite + Tailwind (frontend, as a PWA so it installs on phones), Node + Express (API), MongoDB Atlas, JWT auth with phone OTP + Google login, LiveKit (video), Razorpay Checkout + Route + Payment Links, Google Calendar API, WhatsApp Cloud API or a provider, Resend/Brevo (email), S3 or Cloudinary (documents), node-cron or BullMQ (jobs), Vercel (frontend) + Render/Railway (API).

Pages and features

The MVP is 14 pages; everything in the Later column waits until students are paying and returning.

Page / feature	Who	MVP	Later
Home (story, how it works, two tracks: first job + going abroad)	Public	Yes	Language versions (Kannada, Hindi)
Mentor directory with filters (language, state, college tier, topic, price)	Public	Yes	AI "best match" ranking
Mentor profile (story, background tags, reviews, slots)	Public	Yes	Intro video
Group sessions calendar	Public	Yes	Recurring series
Sign up / login (phone OTP, Google)	All	Yes	—
Matching quiz	Student	Yes	Re-match after 3 sessions
Parent consent + payment link page	Parent	Yes	Parent dashboard
Checkout	Student/parent	Yes	Monthly plan subscriptions
Student dashboard (upcoming, past, notes, credits)	Student	Yes	Goals tracker, roadmap
Session room (video, chat, report button)	Student/mentor	Yes	Whiteboard, screen share for resume review
Rate and review	Student	Yes	—
Mentor application + verification upload	Mentor	Yes	—
Mentor dashboard (availability, sessions, earnings)	Mentor	Yes	Analytics
Admin panel (approve mentors, reports, refunds, bookings)	Admin	Yes	Fraud flags
Programs ("First Internship in 60 Days")	Student	—	Yes
Community / Q&A board	All	—	Yes
College partner dashboard	College	—	Yes
Mobile app	All	—	Yes (start as a responsive web app / PWA)

Design notes: mobile-first (most students use Android phones on mobile data), light pages, simple English with regional-language labels, and the same visual theme as the @refactorsslife channel so viewers recognise it.

Safety and trust

Parents will only pay if the platform feels safe, so safety features are part of the MVP, not an add-on.

Mentor verification

- ID proof + college ID or offer letter / employee ID + LinkedIn, reviewed by a person.
- A short video interview before approval (10 minutes).
- Code of conduct accepted in-app; repeated breaches lead to removal.
- Start invite-only: first 20–30 mentors come from people we know.

Platform rules

- All chat and calls stay on the platform; no phone numbers or social handles in chat for the first sessions (auto-detect and mask).
- 1:1 sessions with under-18 students: allowed only with parent consent; consider group-only for under-18s at launch.
- Report button on every session and profile; admin reviews within 24 hours.
- Mentors are not counsellors: if a student shares serious distress, the mentor follows a written guide that points to professional help and alerts our team.
- No recording by default; if recording is turned on, everyone sees a consent prompt.

Trust signals on the site

- "Verified" badge, number of sessions, ratings.
- Clear refund policy, grievance contact, privacy policy and terms in plain language.

Laws and government policies

The big one is India's data protection law: anyone under 18 needs verifiable parental consent, and full enforcement starts in May 2027, so we build it in from day one. This section is a starting map, not legal advice; confirm the details with a lawyer and a CA before launch.

Area	What applies to us	What we do
DPDP Act 2023 + DPDP Rules 2025	Rules were notified in November 2025 with phased rollout; the main duties (notice and consent, breach reporting, security, children's data) apply from 14 May 2027 (Anantam IAS summary). Breach notification within 72 hours (EY).	Clear privacy notice, consent checkbox per purpose, "delete my data" button, breach response plan, collect only what we need
Children's data (under 18)	Verifiable parental consent before processing; no tracking, behavioural monitoring or targeted ads aimed at children (Seclore). Penalty for breaching children's-data duties can reach ₹200 crore (Sansa Legal).	Age gate at signup; parent consent flow; no ad pixels or retargeting on under-18 accounts; consider launching 18+ only and adding under-18 later
GST	If the platform collects money for mentors' services, it acts as an e-commerce operator; TCS under Section 52 was cut to 0.5% from July 2024 (TaxGuru). Service providers selling through a platform can stay unregistered under ₹20 lakh turnover in most cases (LegalWiz).	Decide with a CA: (a) marketplace model with TCS, or (b) we sell the session and pay mentors a fee. Register GST when required
Payments (RBI rules via Razorpay)	Razorpay Route needs a declared use case for payer-payee transparency	Submit Route use case early; complete mentor KYC
IT Rules (intermediary duties)	Platforms hosting user content generally need terms, a privacy policy and a grievance officer	Publish terms, privacy policy, grievance contact; act on complaints quickly
Consumer protection (e-commerce)	Online sellers of services must show clear prices, refund and cancellation terms, and a grievance process	Prices include taxes, refund policy on checkout page, no hidden fees

Area	What applies to us	What we do
Income tax on mentor payouts	Payouts to mentors may need TDS depending on the model chosen	CA to confirm; collect PAN from every mentor
Abroad mentors	Payments to people abroad and their tax status need care	Start with mentors holding Indian bank accounts; mentors share experience, never visa or immigration advice

Company setup: run this as a registered entity (an LLP or private limited company), not as an individual, before taking payments at scale.

Difficulties and limitations

The hardest problems are not technical: getting mentors and students at the same time, and keeping quality high at a ₹99 price.

Difficulty	Why it's hard	How we handle it
Chicken-and-egg	No students without mentors, no mentors without students	Hand-recruit 20 mentors first; drive students from the YouTube channel
Low prices, thin margins	₹99 sessions leave little room for video, payment fees and support	Group sessions, LiveKit Ship, credits instead of refunds
Payment gateway fees	Razorpay takes a cut of every payment	Build fees into the price; encourage monthly plans over single sessions
Weak internet in small towns	Video drops on mobile data	Audio-only mode, low-resolution default, short sessions
Mentor drop-off	Volunteers lose interest when bookings are slow	Guarantee group slots; show earnings; feature active mentors
Quality varies	One bad mentor ruins trust	Ratings, admin review of low scores, removal after repeated complaints

Difficulty	Why it's hard	How we handle it
Under-18 consent	Verifiable parental consent adds friction	Launch 18+ first, add under-18 with a proper consent flow
Free competition	ADPList offers free 1:1s; YouTube is free	Our edge is relatability, language and structure, not price
Team time	Building while studying	Small MVP, Claude Code for speed, strict scope
Google API / WhatsApp approvals	Template and API approvals take days	Apply in week 1; email fallback

Costs

The MVP can run for under ₹2,000 a month on free tiers; at 1,000 active students, expect roughly ₹10,000–15,000 a month before payment gateway fees.

Item	At launch (per month)	At ~1,000 active students (per month)
Domain	~₹100 (₹1,000/year)	~₹100
Frontend hosting (Vercel)	Free tier	~₹1,700 (pro plan, approximate)
Backend hosting (Render / Railway)	~₹600–1,000	~₹2,000–4,000
Database (MongoDB Atlas)	Free tier	~₹1,000–5,000
Video (LiveKit)	Free (5,000 min)	~₹4,300 (Ship plan, \$50)
WhatsApp reminders (~8 utility messages per student)	Under ₹200	~₹1,200 at ₹0.145 each
Email (Resend / Brevo / SES)	Free tier	~₹0–1,700
File storage (mentor documents)	Free tier	~₹200–500
Payment gateway	Percentage of each payment	Percentage of each payment

Hosting, database and email figures are approximate from memory; check each provider's current pricing page before budgeting. Rupee conversions are approximate.

Build plan with Claude Code

Turn this doc into a small set of Markdown spec files, then build one module per phase with Claude Code, testing each before the next.

Spec files to create in the repo (/docs):

File	Contents
CLAUDE.md	Project summary, stack, folder structure, coding rules, how to run tests
docs/product.md	Users, journeys, pages (sections 2 and 8 of this doc)
docs/data-model.md	Collections and fields (users, mentors, slots, bookings, payments, reviews, reports, consents)
docs/api.md	Every route: method, path, auth, request, response
docs/booking-rules.md	Slot logic, session states, cancellation table
docs/payments.md	Razorpay checkout, webhooks, Route transfers, refunds
docs/video.md	LiveKit token rules and session room behaviour
docs/notifications.md	Event → channel table and templates
docs/safety-and-privacy.md	Verification, consent flow, reporting, data deletion
docs/design.md	Colours, fonts, components matching the YouTube theme

Build phases:

- Foundation (week 1):** repo, React + Vite frontend, Express API, MongoDB, auth (phone OTP + Google), roles (student, mentor, admin).
- Profiles (week 2):** mentor application, admin approval, mentor directory and profile pages, matching quiz.
- Booking (week 3):** availability, slots, holds, booking states, Google Calendar invites.
- Payments (week 4):** Razorpay checkout, webhooks, payment links for parents, credits, refunds.
- Video (week 5):** LiveKit session room, join tokens, report button, audio-only mode.
- Notifications + reviews (week 6):** email, WhatsApp templates, ratings, session summaries.

7. Safety + launch (weeks 7–8): consent flow, chat masking, admin panel, legal pages, load test, soft launch with Phase 0 mentors.

Tips for working with Claude Code:

- One phase per branch; ask for tests with every feature.
- Keep secrets (Razorpay, LiveKit, WhatsApp keys) in `.env`, never in code.
- After each phase, update `CLAUDE.md` so the next session starts with full context.
- Build Route payouts and Google Calendar against test/sandbox accounts first.

Before writing any code: run the Phase 0 pilot (Google Meet + payment links, no app) to confirm students pay and return.

Sources

- [LiveKit Cloud pricing](#)
- [API Cost Calc: LiveKit pricing reference](#)
- [Toolradar: 100ms pricing](#)
- [Fora Soft: Daily.co vs building your own](#)
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- [Razorpay Route docs](#)
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